Chinese government did not suspend outgoing international flights until other countries suspended travel from China which was only in the end of January, allowing folks to travel out of the country, potentially carrying the virus. To note here especially is that, they did put stringent curbs on domestic travel in late January 2020 from the virus hotspots.[5]

Given the density and sheer population of India, once the virus had officially arrived, the possibility of coming in contact with a COVID-19-positive person was very real. This was our very first known case, but it was a solid possibility that there were other patients who had simply gone unnoticed because they hadn't presented themselves at hospitals. If a COVID-19-positive person took a train or an Uber, shared a taxi, bus or autorickshaw or lived in close quarters in our socially tight-knit communities, imagine the number of people they were coming in contact with daily!

As early as 27 January, a German doctor, while exploring Germany's first COVID-19 case had concluded that the infection had gotten transmitted to the country's 33-year-old patient zero from a Chinese business partner, who had displayed no symptoms whatsoever, when they met for meetings near Munich on 20th of that month (a week earlier). Later it was noted that the Shanghai resident who returned to her country on 26 January and began to display symptoms only on her flight back home, had also tested positive.[6] Around the same time, we were hearing in the international media about the viral spread of the pathogen in ski-barns[7], churches[8] and soccer stadiums[9] in Europe. One of the first international outbreaks of the virus was on *Diamond Princess*, a luxury cruise ship stuck in quarantine off the coast of Japan, on which 744 people had tested positive and were locked in their cabins. A hundred and thirty-eight Indians were on board. When health workers on the ship were interviewed, the information all pointed to symptomless spread—they vouched that 70 per cent of the positive patients displayed no symptoms at all.[10] The scientific community also learned innumerable lessons which would be extremely useful in prescribing further strategies, i.e. lessons published in *Infectious Disease Modelling* revealed that locking down people in cabins did have a measurable impact on restricting the contagion and that the ship's waste water and ventilation systems did not seem to worsen the spread of the disease.[11] The international health community debated the concept of